



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: American Leadership Academy

School Website: <https://www.alaschools.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

American Leadership Academy (AZ 85212) exhibits a blend of classical-oriented formation and contemporary schooling structures. The public-facing materials emphasize character formation through a values-based, leadership-centered program (R.A.I.S.E. values: Respect, Accountability, Integrity, Service, Excellence) and a time-proven, core-curriculum approach, rather than a strict Great Books, rigorous grammar-logic-rhetoric sequence typical of some classical programs. While there are clear indications of virtue, moral formation, and family partnership, the materials offer limited explicit references to canonical classical elements such as Great Books, a grammar-logic-rhetoric curriculum, or Socratic pedagogy in the full high-school spectrum. Taken together, the school demonstrates meaningful classical-influenced aspects but does not comprehensively meet the full classical rubric across all six dimensions. Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key contextual notes drawn from the school's public materials include: - ALA emphasizes R.A.I.S.E. leadership values and a moral, wholesome environment that underpins the educational program (evidence of moral formation and virtue-oriented language). - The school frames its approach as "time-proven" and values-based, with an emphasis on forming leaders and partnering with families (evidence of formation-oriented mission and parental partnership). - Curricular emphasis centers on Core Knowledge (not Common Core) and a traditional, time-proven academic structure, rather than explicit Great Books or liberal-arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric), which is a hallmark of classical pedagogy in many programs (evidence of Core Knowledge and traditional curriculum stance). - There is strong emphasis on parent involvement and community engagement (evidence of partnership with families).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence - The school emphasizes a morally grounded environment and values-based programming (R.A.I.S.E. values) as the bedrock of schooling, suggesting an orientation toward virtue and moral formation. This aligns with the classical focus on transcendent moral goods, albeit without explicit theological labeling in the public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: moral, virtue, respect, integrity, service, excellence (all reflected in the R.A.I.S.E. framework and related statements). These terms line up with elements in the canonical classical lexicon that describe virtue formation and moral order (Positive keywords visible in the public materials). - Negative keywords: None clearly present in the public materials (no explicit signaling of secular relativism or value-neutral ethics in the visible content).

Why this rating - The emphasis on moral formation and virtue is a core classical marker, but a lack of explicit references to theology, liturgical practice, or overt transcendental metaphysical framing in the publicly shared materials keeps this at a 'Somewhat Classical' level rather than fully Classical. The public materials foreground character formation and virtue, which are classical strengths, but do not demonstrate the full theological/metaphysical dimension seen in some classical schools.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence - The mission highlights forming leaders through a values-based, time-proven educational approach and emphasizes partnership with families in pursuing an excellent, moral education. This reflects a teleology oriented toward virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing rather than merely vocational outcomes.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, human flourishing, liberal education (inferred by “time-proven, traditional classroom approach” and “values-based curriculum”), moral imagination, education for character. These align with classical aims to cultivate the good, true, and beautiful through formation and virtue. - Negative keywords: None clearly evident in the public materials (no strong signaling of purely utilitarian, career-focused framing).

Why this rating - The school's stated goal centers on character formation and moral leadership within a time-tested framework, aligning with the classical aim of forming virtuous, wise humans rather than focusing solely on job-readiness. The materials support a classical orientation in purpose and telos, warranting a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — [NOT CLASSICAL]

Evidence - The curriculum is described as Core Knowledge (not Common Core) with a time-proven approach, and the materials emphasize a traditional, standards-aligned framework rather than a liberal-arts-centric or Great Books-oriented curriculum. There is no explicit mention of Great Books, Great Conversation, Latin/Greek, or the full liberal arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Core Knowledge (explicitly named), time-proven, traditional classroom approach, value-based curriculum. These terms indicate a structured, content-driven curriculum but not the liberal-arts-centric core of the classical model. - Negative keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation, liberal arts pedagogy (grammar/logic/rhetoric), and explicit classical curriculum markers are not present in the public materials. The absence of these canonical classical curriculum signals is a notable deficit for a CLASSICAL rating.

Why this rating - While the curriculum is described as time-proven and rigorous, it centers on Core Knowledge rather than the liberal-arts framework traditionally associated with classical education (grammar-logic-rhetoric; great books; classical history pedagogy). The absence of explicit classical curriculum hallmarks justifies a NOT CLASSICAL designation for this category.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — [NOT CLASSICAL]

Evidence - Public materials emphasize time-proven, traditional classroom practices and Core Knowledge instruction. There is no explicit reference to classic pedagogical methods such as Socratic seminars, memory work, chanting, narration, recitation, or the upper-school focus on rhetoric and public speaking in the publicly shared materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: time-proven, traditional classroom approach (aligned with a traditional pedagogy but not specifically classical pedagogy). - Negative keywords present: No explicit Socratic seminars, chanting, or memory-based pedagogy; no mention of spoken rhetoric or formal rhetorical exercises in the public materials. The absence of these classical teaching techniques signals a gap relative to a classical pedagogy lexicon.

Why this rating - The pedagogy described aligns more with traditional, content-driven instruction rather than the characteristic classical pedagogy (which often includes Socratic discussion, memorization, recitation, chanting, and structured rhetoric). The lack of explicit classical teaching methods leads to a NOT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 5: Faculty — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence - The school touts highly qualified teachers and a values-oriented environment, with teachers described as part of a school's mission and experience. While there is emphasis on teachers as mentors (through the “live curriculum” concept in classical schools) and on teacher quality, the explicit classical-role language (living curriculum, portraits of teacher/student ideals, classical pedagogy professional formation) is not strongly affirmed in the public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: highly qualified teachers; strong emphasis on a values-driven environment; student-teaching alignment with school mission (evidence of teacher quality and role in education). These align with some classical expectations (though not explicitly the complete classical portrait). - Negative keywords present: The public materials do not explicitly present the “living curriculum” teacher-portrait or the classical faculty archetype (portrait of teacher, faculty as mentors, etc.). The absence of this explicit classical faculty framing reduces the score.

Why this rating - There is clear evidence of strong teacher quality and a values-based environment, but the materials do not fully articulate the classical faculty archetype (living curriculum, teacher as mentor, portrait of what a teacher should be). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 5 rather than full CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents and Community — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence - The school positions itself as a partner with families, emphasizing parental involvement and open accessibility (e.g., partnering with parents, viewing parents as co-teachers, opportunities for parent formation, and visits). Public materials emphasize parent engagement and a hospitable campus culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teaching relationship; parent formation opportunities; open campus/visitation; family involvement in school life. These align with classical expectations for deep parental partnership and community formation (Positive keywords visible). - Negative keywords: None clearly present; the content does not signal a consumerist parent model or minimal parental involvement.

Why this rating - The emphasis on partnering with parents, parental formation opportunities, and welcoming visits strongly supports a classical-community orientation in this category, yielding a CLASSICAL rating.

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicitly integrate Great Books and a Great Conversation framework into the curriculum, with explicit references to Great Books selections and guided Socratic discussion in appropriate grade levels.
- Add a formal grammar-logic-rhetoric sequence (mini-lexicon and program) within the early-middle grades, plus explicit rhetoric training (speech, declamation, public speaking) in upper grades.
- Incorporate classical pedagogical methods (narration/recitation, memory work, chanting) alongside Core Knowledge where possible, with documented implementation details on the website.
- Include explicit theological/metaphysical framing and liturgical/community practices (where appropriate to the school's mission) to strengthen religious foundations and liturgical life if aligned with the school's identity.
- Develop a visible “living curriculum” portrait of the teacher and a formal teacher-mentor framework, including faculty professional development specifically in classical pedagogy.
- Expand publicly available evidence of parental formation programming (book studies, lectures, and family-liturgy aligned events) to reinforce the parents-as-co-teachers model.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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